the BJP to declare its prime ministerial candidate for the 2014 elections by the end of the year. In an interview to the *Economic Times* he said the prime ministerial candidate must have 'secular' credentials. Clearly, Nitish was determined to revive his anti-Modi agenda. Only this time, the BJP wasn't willing to succumb—Nitish's deadline came and went.

By early 2013, Modi, having won the Gujarat elections for a third time, was being talked about as the most likely BJP candidate for the top job. Nitish decided to meet the BJP national leadership to get clarity. Advani reportedly assured him that no such decision had been taken. But when he went for his customary dinner to Jaitley's house, he sensed something amiss. *'Maine kai baar unko poochha, par seedha jawaab nahi mila'* (I asked the question many times, but did not get a straight answer), Nitish told me later. He knew then that the 'Modi for PM' plan of the BJP was now a fait accompli.

A few weeks later, as the BJP formally announced Modi as its campaign committee chief, Nitish decided to break the alliance and run a single-party government. I interviewed Nitish a few days later. On a hot summer day, Nitish seemed at peace with the choice he had made. He said, *'Ek vyakti ne party ko hijack kar diya hai, dictatorship karna chahte hain. Hamare saamne koi option hi nahi tha'* (One man has hijacked the party and is trying to be a dictator. I had no other option). Once again, he steadfastly refused to name Modi even though I tried several times in an hour-long interview to get him to at least acknowledge the Gujarat chief minister.

That evening, on the flight back home, I had the 'Bihar Modi', Sushil Kumar, as my co-passenger. I like Sushil Modi—he strikes me as an honest, thoughtful politician. I asked him why he hadn't tried to prevent the BJP–JD(U) split this time. He, too, said, *'Koi option nahi tha!'* and then offered an anecdote to emphasize his point.

Apparently, the BJP had held a rally a few days earlier to protest against Nitish's decision. At the rally, a BJP worker chanted the names of different party leaders, including Advani and Sushma. The moment he shouted names other than Modi, the crowd began to heckle him: '*Bas Modi ka naam bolo!'* they said. 'Rajdeepji, I have never seen anything like this. *Logon*